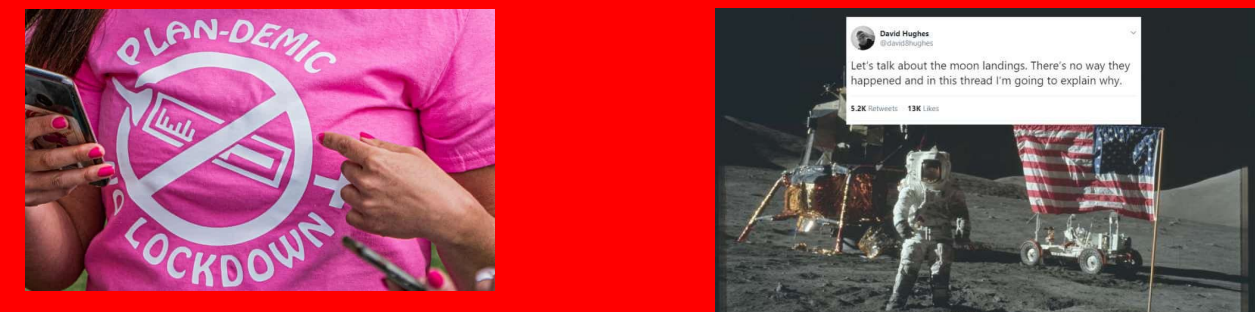
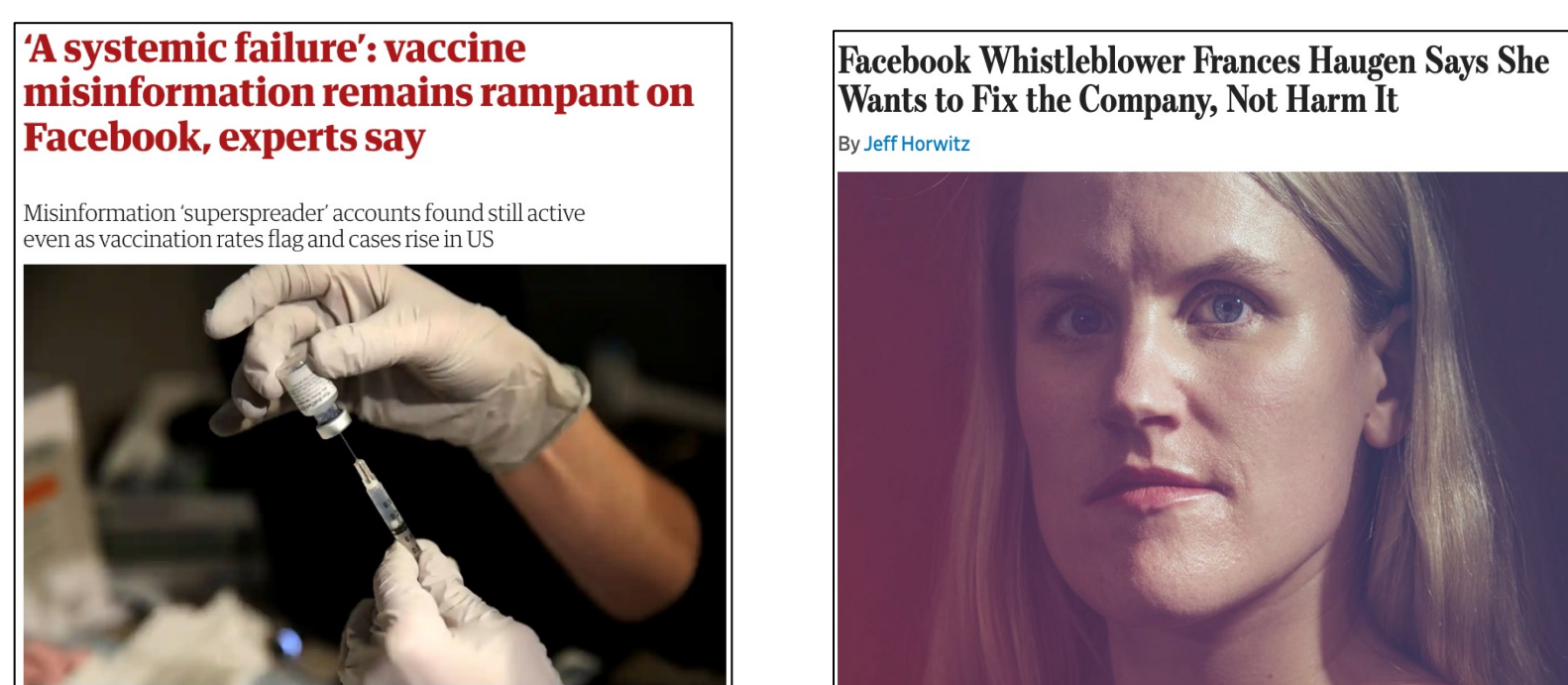


Background

Misinformation Crisis



Primary approach:
Stop the spread of misinformation but...



Another approach:

Promote healthy discourse



- Many factors hinder the flow of information online (e.g., algorithms, s.m. incentives, social pressures, etc.)

&

Self-censorship

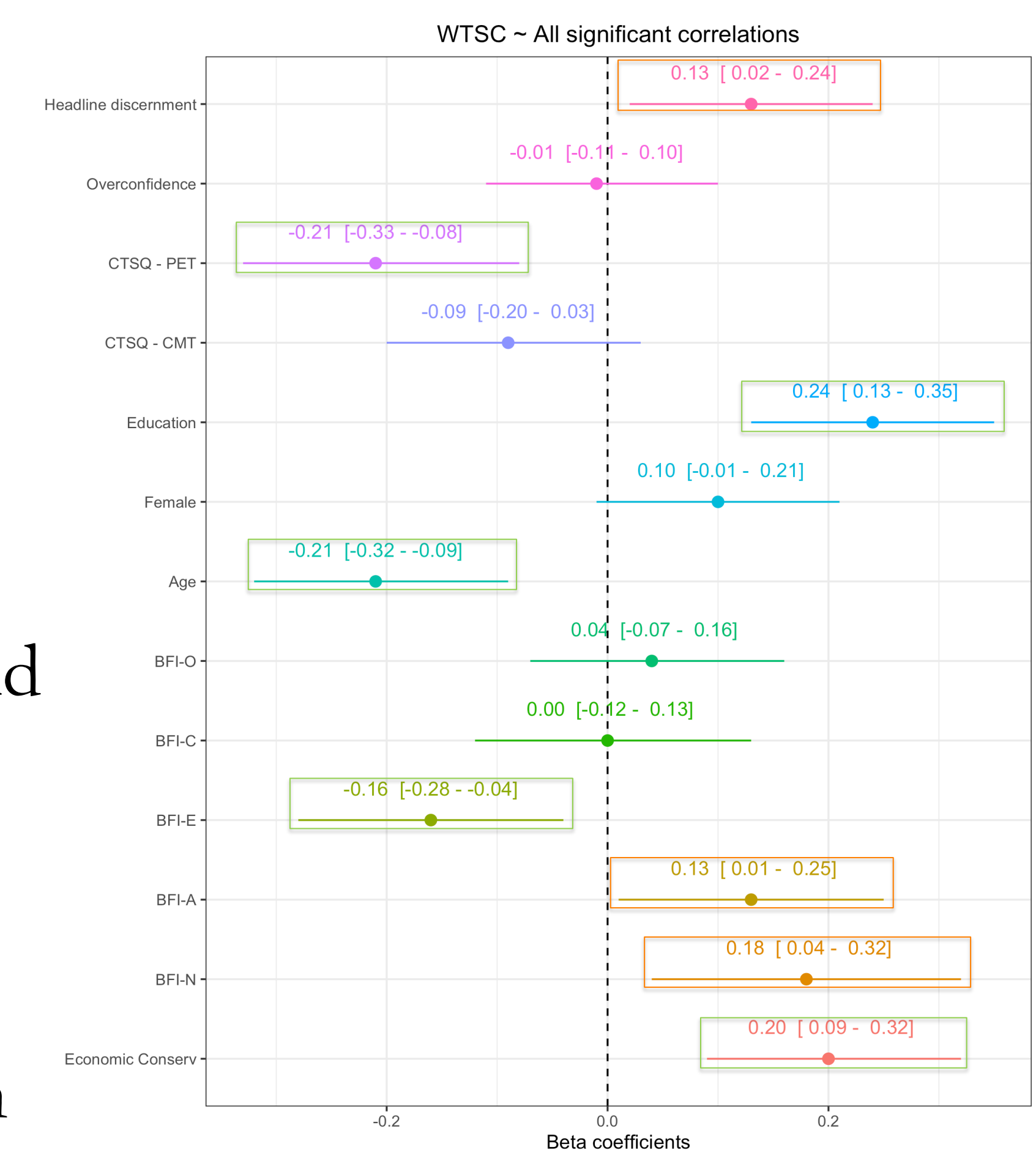
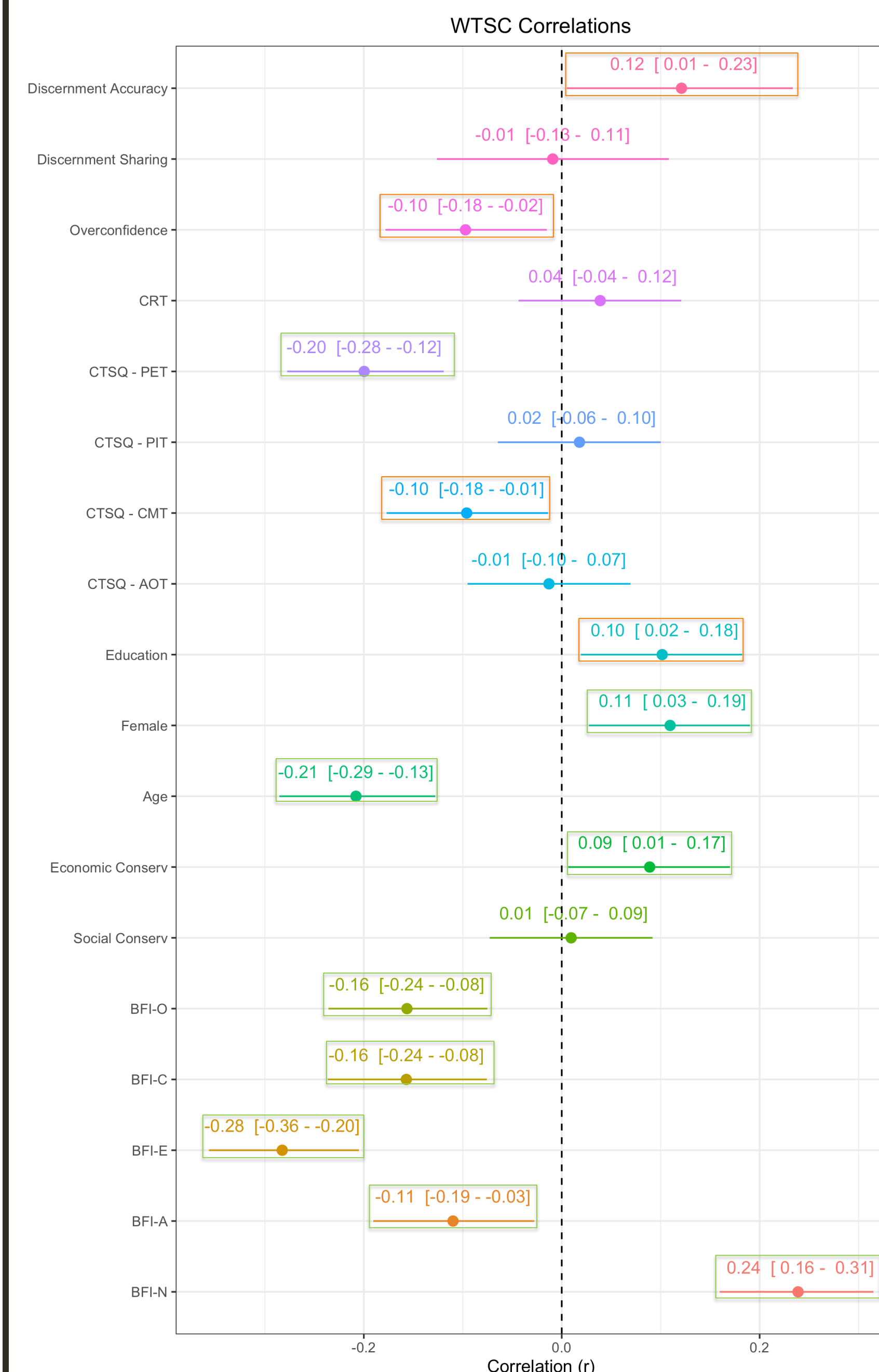
i.e., withholding one's genuine opinion from a group or individual

Question: What contributes to self-censorship?

Results

Take home points:

- Ability to discern T from F headlines was a sig. predictor of self-censorship
- Demographics insights:
 - Women, and people who are older and more educated report increased self-censoring online
- Metacognitive aspects associated with self-censoring but effects were modest
- Neuroticism and introversion strongly predicted self-censorship



List of Abbreviations:
 WTSCS: Willingness to Self-Censor Scale
 CRT: Cognitive Reflection Test
 CTSQ: Comprehensive Thinking Questionnaire
 PET: Preference for Effortful Thought
 PIT: Preference for Intuitive Thought
 CMT: Close-minded Thinking
 AOT: Actively Open-minded Thinking
 BFI: Big Five Inventory (10-items)

$p < .01$ $p < .05$

Current Work

Survey flow

(N = 567 Prolific)

Willingness to Self-Censor Scale (WTSCS)

Headline Task
 General Overconfidence Task (GOT)
 Cognitive Reflection Test (CRT)
 Comprehensive Thinking Styles (CTSQ)
 Big Five Inventory (BFI-10)

Why self-censor question

Demographics

Q#	Statement
1	It is difficult for me to express my opinion if I think others won't agree with what I say.
2	There have been many times when I have thought others around me were wrong but I didn't let them know.
3	When I disagree with others, I'd rather go along with them than argue about it.
4	It is easy for me to express my opinion around others who I think will disagree with me. (R)
5	I'd feel uncomfortable if someone asked my opinion and I knew that he or she wouldn't agree with me.
6	I tend speak my opinion only around friends or other people I trust.
7	It is safer to keep quiet than publicly speak an opinion that you know most others don't share.
8	If I disagree with others, I have no problem letting them know it. (R)

Why do people self-censor?

“Thinking about the last few times you decided to not share your opinion (self-censor) on social media, what were the main reasons you considered when making those decisions?”

Afraid of public backlash

- Safety / Ostracism
 - Audience (e.g., boss, family, etc.)
 - Afraid of the “mob”/ conflict
- n = 264

Value their privacy

- Generally inactive online
 - Topic not important enough
- n = 116

Waste of time, energy, or effort

- Online discourse is hopeless
- n = 130

Social media concerns

- Being removed from platform
- n = 14

Lack knowledge

- Reliability concerns
- n = 18

Limitations:

- Not a representative sample
- Correlational design
- Reliance on self-measures

Future Directions:

- Does the WTSC fully capture self-censorship?
- Is a behavioural measure needed?

